EVOLUTION OF INDIA'S FOREIGN POLICY: 1947–PRESENT

Foreign Policy under Jawaharlal Nehru: The Formative Years

Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru (1947–1964) was not only the first Prime Minister of India but also the chief architect of the Indian foreign policy; for nearly twenty years, he guided the country's participation in the world affairs. Even after his death, his legacy continued till the end of the Cold War and cessation of bipolar politics. This was more because of the fact that the environment of Indian foreign policy did not change much—bipolarity continued till 1990, incessant bitter relations with Pakistan and the China factor remained as constant determinants of the course of Indian foreign policy.

Further, Nehru's views persisted because he was succeeded by individuals who were either unskilled in foreign policy [Lal Bahadur Shastri (1964–1966)] or those who were committed to Nehruvian principles [Indira Gandhi (1966–1977) and (1980–1989) and Rajiv Gandhi (1984–1989)] who were also his daughter and grandson, respectively. Though both had introduced changes in Indian foreign policy, yet they expressed their commitments to the Nehruvian principles. Besides, the long single party domination of Indian politics by the National Congress created generations of Indian politicians and bureaucrats committed to Nehruvianism.[4]

Under Nehru's guidance, Indian foreign policy was the inevitable consequence of the geo-strategic realities of India. Nehru's worldview was conditioned by his belief that the world is not necessarily friendly to a weak and vulnerable state such as India, and that national interests must shape the foreign policy of any state. This way, Nehruvian internationalism was realistic but it was also liberal in the sense that he thought states can rise above "the rigors of anarchy and fashion at least seasons and locales of peace and cooperation. They must do so because power politics is flawed and will end in catastrophe". Therefore, in many instances, Nehru himself wavered continually between idealism and national egoism or realism and, under such reductionist realism, Nehru pursued policies that advanced national interest as well as included a good measure of idealism or liberal internationalism.